



THE EGYPTIAN • WESTERN DESERT

09

The Extensive Western Desert Tour

*The ultimate crossing — 1,010 km off-road, Abu
Moharek, the Whale Valley and Lake Qarun*

A journey you can picture yourself inside

The ultimate Western Desert tour: a long, rich journey packed with history, geology, endless horizons and landscapes. Old unknown camel routes, long-gone rally tracks, and places once inhabited by cave-men, Pharaohs, Romans and modern man. Eighteen nights in the deep desert before the first hotel.

The ninth of nine and the deepest. It carries everything the shorter tours reach and adds Abu Moharek end to end, the Pink Panther plateau, the abandoned royal railway, the Whale Valley and Lake Qarun.

THE NINE, BY LENGTH IN DAYS

01	02	03	04	05	06	07	08	09
3	4	4	5	7	12	12	15	20

SHORTEST

EACH IS BOOKED ON ITS OWN

DEEPEST

HOW YOU TRAVEL

Vehicle · Deep desert camping. Cairo return · 20 days · 4 to 20 travellers. Each of the nine journeys is a separate booking with its own start and finish; none is a stage of another.

IMPORTANT

This is the intended route, not a fixed timetable.

It communicates the ground covered, the pace and the level of effort. Named properties, exact camp locations, departure times, prices and meal inclusions are confirmed at booking. Weather, park authorities, soft sand and vehicle recovery can change the order or content of a day; this guide names those dependencies wherever they affect your choice.

Every day carries the same four facts

ROUTE

Where the day starts, what it passes through and where it ends.

SLEEP

Tent or bed, and where. Camps are chosen on the day; the area is fixed, the exact spot is not.

DISTANCE

Kilometres where the source gives them, on foot for the walking tours, otherwise an estimate.

MEALS

What is included that day. Anything not listed is not included.

RHYTHM

A reading of how much the day asks of you, followed by the kind of ground it crosses.

■ Easy

Road transfer, an oasis day, or a short walk. Recoverable.

■ Steady

A full day of driving or walking, with stops. The normal shape.

■ Demanding

Long hours, soft sand, recovery work or a hard walk. Plan around it.

FREE TIME

Noted where a day holds unstructured hours. Desert days rarely do; the group moves together and the camp is made together.

The Extensive Western Desert Tour

NIGHTS CAMPING	18 · nights 1–18
NIGHTS IN HOTELS	1 · Tunis Village, night 19
OFF-ROAD DISTANCE	1,010 km logged by day 12, and more after
GROUND COVERED	Black Desert · Agabat · White Desert · Karaween · Dakhla Dunes · Kharafesh · Gozmond · Shaw Shaw · Wadi Jahanam · Pink Panther Plateau · Abu Moharek · Minya and Samuel Dunes · Whale Valley · Lake Qarun

HOW THE DAYS GROUP

Baharia to the White Desert	Days 1–4
The dunes to Gozmond	Days 5–8
Wadi Jahanam and the Pink Panther	Days 9–11
Abu Moharek end to end	Days 12–16
Fayoum, the whales and home	Days 17–20

01 Cairo — Baharia — Sheikh Abdullah Labyrinth

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Cairo → Baharia Oasis → Black Desert → Sheikh Abdullah Labyrinth	Camp · Sheikh Abdullah Labyrinth	370 km road + 30 km off-road	Lunch, dinner

EASY · ROAD AND OFF-ROAD

An early start west, with lunch on a local farm in the oasis. Then into the 4WDs for the Black Desert, whose volcanic dolerite dates to the Jurassic, 180 million years ago. Camp is made in the Sheikh Abdullah Labyrinth, where neolithic tools sometimes surface.

02 Sheikh Abdullah — Rajeh Dunes — Agabat

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Sheikh Abdullah → English track → Rajeh Dunes → Agabat	Camp · Agabat	40 km off-road	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

STEADY · DUNE

A sunrise walk through the labyrinth, then a faster pace on the flat English track — part of the camel route that linked Baharia to Farafra. Sandboarding at the Rajeh dunes, then the descent into Agabat with its mix of huge chalk formations and sand.

03 Agabat — Serw — El Wadi

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Agabat → Ein El Serw Roman graves and well → Wadi Al Kabir	Camp · Wadi Al Kabir	50 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ STEADY · OFF-ROAD

The ancient Roman graves at the Ein El Serw well, which still produces fresh water — a vital source in an arid area. Then the descent into the Wadi Al Kabir, where the water table sits close to the surface and palms and acacias still grow, with lunch in the shade of a big acacia.

04 El Wadi — Ein Khadra — White Desert

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Wadi Al Kabir → Wadi Al Saghir → Ein Khadra → El Santa → White Desert National Park	Camp · White Desert National Park	40 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ STEADY · OFF-ROAD

Across the little plateau separating the two wadis to the second Roman well at Ein Khadra and more graves, then El Santa, the 2,000-year-old acacia. The day ends touring the White Desert National Park and camping as far from other groups as the park allows.

NOTE The White Desert is the most visited part of the Western Desert — over 50,000 visitors a year, and 150 to 300 campers a night in winter.

05 White Desert — Karaween — Crescent Dunes

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
White Desert → English Track → Karaween Dunes → Crescent Dunes	Camp · Crescent Dunes	40 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ DEMANDING · DUNE

An early walk, then east-north-east on a slower, rougher reach of the English Track. Open sand with bushes and camel grass, firewood collected along the way, and dune surfing at Karaween before the harder crescents, where softer sand means a better chance of getting stuck.

06 Crescent Dunes — Karaween Sand Sheet — Dakhla Dunes

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Crescent Dunes → Karaween sand sheet → Black Valley camel route → WW2 airfield → Dakhla Dunes	Camp · Dakhla Dunes	180 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ DEMANDING · DUNE

A bigger drive but a smooth one, south across the Karaween sand sheet past new desert farms — an odd contrast of green, yellow and blue. Then the old Farafra-Dakhla camel route, the Black Valley, used by the British before and during the war, by the Dakar Rally in 2003 and the Pharaohs Rally many times since. A WW2 landing strip is visited on the way.

07 Dakhla Dunes – Kharafesh – Gozmond

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Dakhla Dunes → Kharafesh → Gozmond → Bab El Gozmond	Camp · Gozmond Labyrinth	60 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ DEMANDING · REMOTE

The dunes open into separate barchans and the English track reappears, hard this time. Kharafesh is a maze of sand passages and marble mounds, with very soft sand right beside the rock. Gozmond’s marble hills are bigger again; the drive reaches Bab El Gozmond, the gate of the descent to Dakhla, for photographs only.

NOTE	Neolithic sites are scattered through Gozmond and are stopped at along the way.
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08 Gozmond – Shaw Shaw Mountain

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Gozmond Labyrinth → Shaw Shaw Mountain and Ridge → Cathedral dune → Shaw Shaw Dunes	Camp · north of the Shaw Shaw ridge	70 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ STEADY · DUNE

North-east on sand, rock and packed track to the Shaw Shaw area and its complex soft dunes. A giant Cathedral dune is stopped at and, for those who want it, climbed. Another neolithic site is walked before camp on a picturesque spot north of the ridge.

09 Shaw Shaw — Wadi Jahanam

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Shaw Shaw Dunes → Dakhla dune chains → Wadi Jahanam → Rajeh Plateau and Darb Al Tawil	Camp · among the hills of Darb Al Tawil	130 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ DEMANDING · DUNE

East across the parallel chains of the Dakhla dunes to Wadi Jahanam, Hell's Valley, named for its summer heat and known for scattered acacias and, with luck, dorcas gazelles. The day ends where the Rajeh Plateau meets the Darb Al Tawil camel route to the Nile.

10 Wadi Jahanam — Abu Moharek — Pink Panther Maze

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Wadi Jahanam → new road east → Abu Moharek barchans → Pink Panther Plateau	Camp · Pink Panther Plateau	65 km off-road + 80 km road	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ STEADY · REMOTE

Sandy paths to a newly finished road, tyres inflated away from the tarmac, then eighty kilometres east before dropping south onto the broken barchans of Abu Moharek. The Pink Panther plateau is a maze of pink marble mounds with hard-packed sand passages between them.

NOTE	Likely the coldest night of the trip — the plateau stands high and the temperature drops fast after dark.
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11 Pink Panther Maze — Abu Moharek

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Pink Panther Plateau → crescents → Darb Al Tawil and Darb Al Khoshby → mid-chain Abu Moharek	Camp · mid-chain	80 km off-road	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ DEMANDING · DUNE

North through the maze to the crescents, over the road, and on into the middle of the dunes. The route crosses the Darb Al Tawil and Darb Al Khoshby camel tracks; ancient pottery and the leavings of long-gone travellers turn up on the surface.

12 Abu Moharek

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Abu Moharek — criss-crossing the chain	Camp · among the dunes	90 km · 1,010 km off-road to date	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ DEMANDING · DUNE

A full day inside Egypt’s longest chain of dunes, the vehicles lighter now for the fuel and water burned. Fulgurites, old pottery, ostrich egg shells and ancient fuel tins surface where the wind has moved; Abu Moharek keeps its secrets covered and uncovers them at random.

13 Abu Moharek — Djara Cave — Abu Moharek

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Abu Moharek → Farafra–Dayrut road fuel stop → Djara Cave → Abu Moharek	Camp · Abu Moharek	110 km off-road + 60 km road	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ STEADY · CAVE AND DUNE

Out to the gas station on the Farafra–Dayrut road to refuel, then forty kilometres to the Djara Cave — North Africa’s largest stalactite and stalagmite cave, with cave-man rock art most visitors miss. Back onto Abu Moharek afterwards, into very heavy loose sand.

NOTE The only resupply of the twenty days.

14 Abu Moharek — East Moharek

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Abu Moharek → complex crescents → Darb El Rubi and Darb El Bahnasa → the giant cairn	Camp · Abu Moharek	50 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ DEMANDING · DUNE

Into a harder part of the chain, where the complex crescents make for few miles and many smiles. The day reaches Darb El Rubi and Darb El Bahnasa, the camel routes linking Baharia to Fayoum and Minya, and a giant cairn that must have taken days to build.

15 Abu Moharek — the Royal Train Track

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Abu Moharek east → Block House 6 → second cairn → eroded formations	Camp · among the eroded hills	50 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ STEADY · REMOTE

A hundred and ten years ago, under King Fouad, engineers began a railway to link Minya to Baharia. After 130 km of track the project met Abu Moharek and stopped dead. Block House 6, the last building on the line, still stands. The day ends among water- and wind-eroded hills that prove this ground was once under the sea.

16 Abu Moharek — Minya Dunes

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Abu Moharek → Minya road → Minya Dunes	Camp · Minya Dunes	70 km off-road + 120 km road	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ STEADY · DUNE

North out of the hills to the Minya road, 120 km east, then north-east across gravel and farm track to the overlapping crescent dunes of Minya. Newly developed farmland may slow the crossing.

17

Minya — Samuel Dunes — Qosor El Arab

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Minya Dunes → Samuel Dunes → Pipe Rock → Qosor El Arab dunes	Camp · near the top of the plateau	70 km	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ STEADY · DUNE

The Minya dunes are also called the Samuel dunes, after a hidden monastery in the middle of them. The Pipe Rock offers shade for a break; the day ends on the Qosor El Arab dunes, which ride a plateau and give the best sunset of the trip.

18

Qosor El Arab — Whale Valley — Magic Lake

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Qosor El Arab → Wadi Al Hitan (Whale Valley) → Magic Lake → Samuel Dunes	Camp · Samuel Dunes	90 km off-road + 25 km road	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

■ STEADY · SITES AND DUNE

North into the Whale Valley National Park, with a hike and the museum, then thirty kilometres of hard corrugated track out to the Magic Lake and its photo plateau. Back to the Samuel dunes for the last night under canvas.

19 Samuel Dunes – Tunis Village

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Samuel Dunes → road → Tunis Village	Hotel · Tunis Village	20 km off-road + 60 km road	Breakfast, lunch, dinner

EASY · VILLAGE

A short run on the dunes to the road and on to Tunis, the pottery village, and the first hotel of the trip — a well-deserved shower and a bed. Dinner in a local restaurant and the pottery shops for hand-made souvenirs.

NOTE	Night nineteen. The first bed in eighteen days.
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20 Tunis Village – Lake Qarun – Cairo

ROUTE	SLEEP	DISTANCE	MEALS
Tunis Village → Lake Rayyan → Lake Qarun → Moer’s Shores → Dimeh Al Siba’e Ruins → Cairo	—	20 km off-road + 120 km road	Breakfast, lunch

EASY · RETURN

North along Lake Rayyan to Lake Qarun, with a walk at Moer’s Shores through a neolithic site, then Dimeh Al Siba’e — a Greco-Roman city founded in the third century BC by Ptolemy II, with ten-metre mudbrick walls, two temple foundations and what is held to be the world’s oldest man-made road. The final lunch is taken here.

NOTE	Estimated arrival in Cairo 4–5pm.
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What the price carries, and what it does not

INCLUDED

- Assembly pickup and drop-off at an agreed Cairo location
- Hotel accommodation for 1 night (Tunis Village, night 19)
- Transport in reliable Toyota Landcruisers for the entire journey
- All meals listed in the itinerary
- Drinks, snacks and fruit – water, tea, coffee, mint
- Desert gear: kitchen, camping and recovery equipment
- Tents, sleeping mats, sleeping bags and blankets
- A friendly, English-speaking, experienced guide and a cook for the journey

NOT INCLUDED

- White Desert and Whale Valley National Park tickets
- Site and museum entry tickets
- Personal expenses
- Travel and medical insurance
- Alcoholic beverages
- Tips and gratuities

RATES

Priced on enquiry.

The source itinerary publishes no rate card. Every one of these journeys is quoted against the group – its size, its dates and any tailoring – so the figure is set on enquiry. This panel is reserved for the rate line and the deposit terms once you supply them.

Where this journey asks more of you

Eighteen consecutive nights in the deep desert. The first bed and the first proper shower come on night nineteen at Tunis Village.

Fuel and water are carried; a single resupply run to the Farafra–Dayrut road falls on day thirteen.

Getting stuck is part of the itinerary and is written into it. Recovery work is shared.

The coldest night of the trip is likely on the Pink Panther plateau, which stands high above sea level.

Active November to April. Groups of 4 to 20.

SEASON

Active November to April. Outside that window the heat makes the deep desert unworkable.

PHYSICAL DEMAND

Minimum endurance to walk the sites, the temples and the desert hikes, and to sit long hours in a vehicle over rough ground.

GROUP

4 to 20 travellers. Departures are private to the group.

VEHICLES AND GEAR

Toyota Landcruisers, stocked with supplies, kitchen, camping and recovery gear. Tents, mats, sleeping bags and blankets are provided.

TAILORING

This journey can be tailored for a specific number of travellers, and the day order can be adjusted around your dates. Contact us for an offer.

From this guide to a confirmed departure

01

Tell us the shape of the group

Numbers, dates in the November-to-April window, and anything the itinerary should bend around — age, mobility, diet, or a date that matters.

02

Receive the offer

A quoted price against that group, with the lodges named, the vehicles counted and the inclusions fixed against this itinerary.

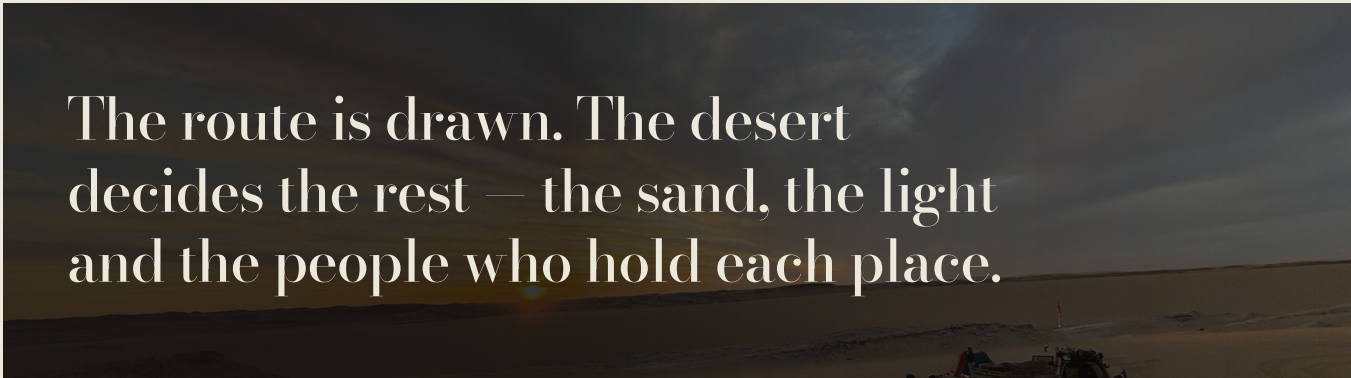
03

Confirm and prepare

A kit list, park ticket costs, insurance requirements and the final day plan follow confirmation.

ENQUIRIES

This journey can be tailored for a specific number of travellers. Contact us for an offer against your own dates.



The route is drawn. The desert
decides the rest — the sand, the light
and the people who hold each place.